ON HIGH GROUND

A majority of the respondents approve of how the Centre has handled the face-off with China in Ladakh. Most also think now is not the time to talk with Pakistan

By **PRADIP R. SAGAR**

Currently, the biggest foreign policy challenge India faces is the stand-off between the Indian Army and the People's Liberation Army of China along the Line of Actual Control in eastern Ladakh and Arunachal Pradesh and the resultant frosty ties with China. When army chief Gen. Manoj Pande says the situation on the border with China is "stable but unpredictable", he means that further misadventure by the PLA has been checked by the large-scale deployment of men and military assets. However, the PLA consistently attempts to alter the status quo, like the recent intrusion effort in Tawang. Overall, 17 rounds of corps commander-level talks as well as diplomatic negotiations have failed to bring complete disengagement. So far, dispute over five of seven friction points in eastern Ladakh is resolved.

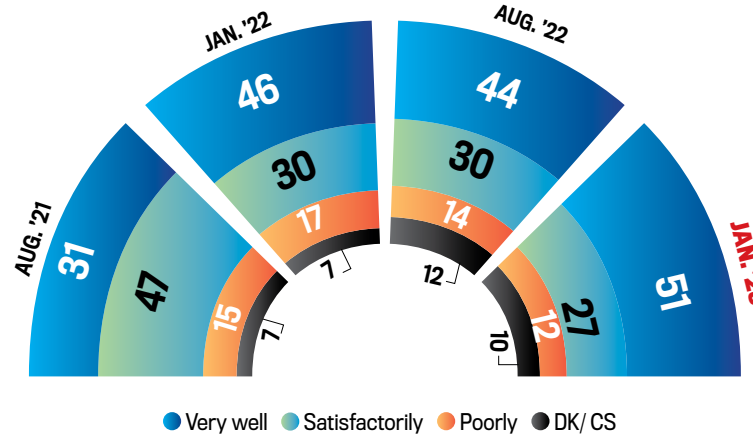
How has the Centre handled the border intrusions by China? 'Very well', say over 50 per cent of the INDIA TODAY-CVoter Mood of the Nation respondents, while 27 per cent say it is 'satisfactory'. Only 11 per cent believe they were handled poorly. Congress leader Rahul Gandhi and some opposition parties have accused the Modi government of hiding facts about China's intrusion, even saying it has usurped 2,000 sq km of our territory. The Centre refutes the charges. A majority of MOTN respondents believe the Centre. Around 55 per cent believe the Modi government, but 31 per cent do not.

Besides political leadership, the Indian military has also been equipped with the world's best military platforms and a massive push towards infrastructure development along the LAC. All this is in retaliation to China's aggressive and unprecedented build-up of men, materiel and infrastructure along the LAC and in rear areas.

Keeping all this in mind, over 54 per cent of the respondents believe that a border war with China is becoming inevitable, while 30 per cent think otherwise.

Since the Galwan clash in June 2020, there have been calls for Indians to boycott Chinese goods. However, India's imports from China have registered a sharp increase instead. As per Chinese customs data, India-China trade touched an all-time high of $135.98 billion in 2022, while New Delhi's trade

HOW HAS THE CENTRAL GOVERNMENT HANDLED THE BORDER INTRUSIONS FROM CHINA SO FAR?



All figures in % and rounded off; DK/ CS: Don't know/ Can't say